

The White Nile and The Sudd Centre (WNSC)

Concept Note

Juba, Republic of South Sudan

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I. Context

“Water is life.” Surface water, groundwater, rainfall and wetlands are the core renewable natural resources for sustainable livelihoods in South Sudan. The White Nile and The Sudd together with the associated tributaries, systems, streams, creeks, lakes, floodplains, and meadows, have sustained for ages the lifelines of peoples, livestock, wildlife, fisheries, plants, insects and birds in South Sudan and neighbouring environs. These special natural treasures should be cherished, preserved, and protected. The Nile Basin Initiative (NBI) and Ramsar Convention on Wetlands are some of the available regional and international cooperation mechanisms that South Sudanese must uphold to significantly for water and wetlands security.

It is noticeable that oil exploitation and pollution have adversely affected the natural ecosystems in South Sudan. Some unregulated infrastructural development activities have also tempered with the indigenous topography and hydrology. Further, climate change and extreme weather patterns have induced recurring floodings. Rivers have been bursting their banks, killing people, destroying properties, and causing unprecedented displacements. Paradoxically, some parts of the country have been facing drought cycles. Moreover, during the decades of civil wars big number of the population have moved closer to rivers and settled in green floodplains, swamps, and water ways (widely known as *Toic*). All these intricate problems and life-threatening risks require evidence-based policy attention and sustainable solutions.

II. Problem Statement

A series of events are bound to affect The White Nile and The Sudd, especially the projects of rivers dredging and resumption of the Jonglei Canal. Among these are the passing of Resolution Number 2/2020 by the Council of Ministers of the Republic of South Sudan on 25 September 2020 and the signing of the Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) on 28 July 2021 between the respective ministries of Water Resources and Irrigation of the Republic of South Sudan and the Arab Republic of Egypt. While these decisions were made behind closed doors, the leakage of presentation by the then Minister of Water Resources and Irrigation to the Council of

Ministers in March 2021 and the news about the arrival of heavy-duty dredging machines and other assorted equipment from Egypt through the Sudan in June 2022, heightened the concerns and rekindled the memories about public protests against Jonglei Canal Project in the 1970s.¹

The Sudd Wetlands² was designated as the World's second largest Ramsar Site of international biosphere significance in June 2006. The World's Heritage Site Gap Analysis Report of 2013 by the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) categorized the Sudd Wetlands as one of the 228 sites that should be preserved and considered among the "Global 200: Priority Ecoregions". In 2017, the Government of the Republic of South Sudan applied to UNESCO to designate *The Sudd Wetlands, Boma-Badingilo Migratory Landscape and Deim Zubeir*³ as world's heritage sites to be protected. The assessment made by Government of South Sudan and development partners have valued The Sudd Wetlands at a price of 3 billion United States Dollars annually through its utmost potentials for tourism, fisheries, livestock, and ecosystem services, among others.

However, risks are high on The White Nile and The Sudd as well as on the associated water resources and wetlands if dredging of rivers and resumption of Jonglei Canal Project become operationalized without prior consideration of credible Feasibility Studies (FSs) and Environmental and Social Impact Assessments (ESIAs). Though the MOU between Egypt and South Sudan provided for ESIA, it only listed this as a last activity. This is like putting the cart before the horse while the best practice requires validating the commencement of such kind of project once credible FSs and ESIAs are in place first! The MOU also included a confidentiality clause to prevent the implementing authorities from revealing any information to the public unless agreed in advance by all the signatories, forgetting that this has no legal weight.

The experts and the citizens are deeply concerned about the unimaginable negative environmental impacts on ecosystems of The White Nile and The Sudd if dredging and resumption of the digging of Jonglei Canal are conducted. The traditional livelihoods of the people and their immediate neighbours in the region will be greatly tempered with, particularly when there is no information, no consultations, and no credible FSs/ESIAs provided to determine the viability and value of such activities.

¹ The Jonglei Canal Project was proposed in 1904 by a British official during the Anglo-Egyptian Rule in the Sudan. The purpose was to minimize evaporations in the Sudd wetlands where over 50% of freshwater spread out into the vast and absorptive low topographical landscapes, preventing faster discharge downstream. If completed the Project would have covered a length of 360 km, a width of 54 meters, a depth of 4.5 meters, and a water carrying capacity of 25 million cubic meters per day with discharge of 4.8 billion cubic meters annually downstream to Sudan and Egypt. The French engineering firm, Compagnie des Constructions Internationales (CCI), was contracted by the Sudan's Government in Khartoum to commence the digging of Jonglei Canal in 1978. It has to be recalled that Chapter Five, 14(a) of the SPLM/A Manifesto of 31st July 1983 spelt out the construction of Jonglei Canal and involvement of Egyptians as the cause of massive unrest in Southern Sudan where 3 students were killed, and several politicians arrested for protesting these.

² Designated size of The Sudd Wetlands, according to the 2007 Sudan Post-conflict Environmental Assessment, is 57,000 km² though the actual extended size is about 130,000 km². The Sudd is an ecological region where over thirty (30) rivers converge to form vast and diversified flora and fauna with unique aquatic vegetation and roaming wildlife. It is a natural reservoir described as a place where fish die of old age.

³ Deim Zubeir was a slave trade center in Bahr El Ghazal during the Turko-Egyptian Rule.

III. Public Reactions and Government Intervention

As the news of dredging became widespread and alarming, individual experts, ordinary members of the public, media outlets, think tanks, universities, members of parliament and some top government officials objected in an unprecedented manner. The objections by experts, the opposing debates in social media, the public outcry, and the statements by top government officials about the dredging and resumption of Jonglei Canal Project, all became dangerously divisive and polarizing. The Ministry of Environment and Forestry had to call a press conference to distance itself from the planned dredging, terming it as “illegal”.

As the situation became alarming, an informal group comprising of national Members of Parliament (MPs) as well as national and international experts emerged and organized under the leadership of Hon. Joshua Dau Diu. They called themselves “Save The Nile and The Sudd Region”. They were joined by other like-minded pressure groups with similar objectives, namely: Prof. John Akech Apuruot and his online followers/students; Hon. Bor Gatwech Kuany and “Save The Sudd and the Greenbelts of South Sudan Group”; Ustaz Francis Telar Mayen and “Anti-Nile Dredging/Canal Group”; Hon. Andres Gach Gatluak and “Save The Sudd Campaign Foundation Group”; and Mr. Gatluke Chuol and “Stop the Nile Dredging Group”, among others. To date Save The Nile and The Sudd Region Group continued to meet in De Havana to discuss issues affecting the rivers, the Sudd and the other wetlands, greenbelts of South Sudan, and livelihoods of the people of South Sudan.

These moves, among others, caught the attention of the President of the Republic of South Sudan to de-escalate the tensions. He directed in his speech on the 11th Anniversary of the Independence the freezing of all dredging activities on Bahr El Ghazal/Naam River until credible and professional ESIA is carried out by the Ministry of Environment and Forestry to recommend the best course of evidence-based scientific actions and guidance after determining the viability of the project and its environmental safety to the nature and the citizens.

The public consultations were conducted during the period of 10th – 14th July 2022, convened by the Office of the President of the Republic. The consultations were organized by a committee chaired by Akoch Akuei Manhiem and facilitated by international and national experts headed by Prof. Tag Elkhazin and Deng Majok Chol respectively. The report of the consultations was submitted on 5th August 2022 to the Minister of Presidential Affairs with recommendations on what need to be done for the interest of South Sudan. Save the Nile and the Sudd Region Group also produced an Urgent Memo addressed to the President of the Republic to take note of security, environmental, humanitarian, legal and political implications of the dredging and the digging of Jonglei Canal. The Memo was submitted to the Minister of Presidential Affairs on 11th August 2022 and shared widely with the media thereafter.

IV. What is Next?

Charting the way into the future, the Group of De Havana in Juba and others who joined it resolved to transform themselves from being informal and fluid pressure groups that meets

occasionally into a formal legal entity with clear national, scientific, technical, and professional objectives. They endorsed “The White Nile and The Sudd Centre (WNSC)” as the new name. This Centre will be registered as a national think tank oriented towards studies, research, presentations, policy, education, awareness, advocacy, lobbying, networking, and learning on water resources and wetlands of South Sudan.

The main areas of focus of the WNSC shall include hydrology, meteorology, environment, climate change, energy, food security, agriculture and irrigation, water management, wildlife, livestock, fisheries, forestry, law, hydro-politics, water diplomacy, sustainable development, peoples’ livelihood, among other cross-cutting topics such as mineral and oil exploitation. It shall document information and generate scientific analyses of issues connected to The White Nile River basin and its tributaries/catchments, The Sudd Region and other wetlands, the infrastructural development projects, the natural resources, and the ecological systems.

V. Objectives

The overarching objective of the WNSC is to promote sustainable preservation, utilization, development, management, and control of The White Nile, The Sudd Wetlands and other associated natural resources, including aquifers and rainfall catchments/watersheds, to meet the best interest and prosperity of the people of South Sudan.

The specific objectives of the of the WNSC include, *inter alia*, the following key areas:

1. To promote evidence-based policy making on development of water resources, wetlands and greenbelts using scientific approach.
2. To conduct research, studies, analyses, awareness, training, and advocacy on The White Nile River Basin and associated water hydrology as well as The Sudd and associated wetlands and the greenbelt ecology.
3. To recommend safer and suitable solutions guided by environmentally friendly technical know-how on exploitation of natural resources of South Sudan.
4. To promote a people-centred sustainable development in South Sudan.
5. To adopt coping mechanisms that will mitigate the impact of climate change and extreme weather patterns in South Sudan, especially floods and droughts.
6. To connect the national experts regionally and globally with the international experts for wider networking and friendships around the systems of conservation, protection and prudent utilization of natural resources.

VI. Areas of Strategic Focus

1. The White Nile River and its tributaries.
2. The Sudd Region and the associated water resources and wetlands.
3. Natural resources, environmental sustainability, and floods/droughts mitigation and adaptation.

4. Hydrology, Hydraulics, Ecology, Law, politics, economics, anthropology, diplomacy, security, and infrastructure.
5. Sustainable development, local livelihoods, peace, and integration.
6. The Nile Basin Initiative (NBI) and Cooperative Framework Agreement (CFA).
7. UNESCO's Heritage and Ramsar Sites.
8. Bilateral MoUs and Agreements on Water, Wetlands and Greenbelts.

VII. Activities and Operations

1. Evidence-based conversations and writings on The White Nile River and its tributaries with the associated water/wetlands resources, the Greenbelt, and the ecosystems with the contained biodiversity of peoples, livestock, wildlife, fisheries, birds, and vegetation species in South Sudan.
2. Documentation of information and analyses of The White Nile River, Bahr El Jebel River, Bahr El Ghazal/Naam River, Sobat River and their tributaries with all the associated water resources and wetlands in South Sudan.
3. Scientific studies/research for generation of evidence-based public policies and programmed actions on restoration, protection and conservation of The Sudd and the associated wetlands of South Sudan with the contained fauna and flora.
4. Feasibility Studies (FSs), Environmental and Social Impact Assessments (ESIAs) on major developmental projects and infrastructural constructions that have implications on water resources and wetlands of South Sudan.
5. Work in partnership with The Sudd Resource and Research Centre (SRRC) of the University of Juba, the Beriberi Academy and other relevant institutions and think tanks in South Sudan and abroad.
6. Networking, Lobbying and Advocacy on water resources, wetlands, and greenbelts of South Sudan.

VIII. Cadre Capacity Development

1. Provision and development of water resources knowledge and scientific skills.
2. Institutional support, technical assistance, information management, and technological know-how facilitated by efficient tools and equipment.
3. Job opportunities and career development path.

IX. Organizational Structuring and Business

1. Write the Constitution of "The White Nile and The Sudd Centre (WNSC)" and register it as a legal entity in the Republic of South Sudan.
2. Design organizational structure, job descriptions and management outlooks of WNSC.
3. Create Standards Operation Procedures (SOPs) for the business model of WNSC.
4. Identify the sources of funding and design the strategy for activities and operations.